

Questions and Answers

Capabilities/Past Performance/Organizational Independence

1. How will the government define organizational independence— will this standard apply only to the prime contractor, or to the entire performing team including subcontractors and teaming partners?

Answer 1: The feasibility study shall be conducted in an objective, non-partisan, and independent manner. This expectation applies to the prime contractor and all members of the team, including subcontractors and teaming partners.

Interested parties shall ensure that any actual or potential organizational conflicts of interest, including financial, organizational, or other interests that could impair objectivity, are identified and mitigated in accordance with applicable Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR) requirements. (FAR Subpart 9.5, Organizational and Consultant Conflicts of Interest)

The Government may require disclosure of relevant past or current work that could present a conflict or perceived lack of objectivity.

Scope/Constraints/Performance Objectives/Deliverables

2. Is this study focused only on USDA Forest Service impacts, or does it include the Department of the Interior bureaus as well?

Answer 2: The feasibility study is focused on impact analysis associated with USDA Forest Service operations and wildland fire operations of state, local, and tribal governments.

3. Is the scope subject to change based on further discussions with the appropriators (as specified in the original Congressional appropriations language) and, if so, will the contract include a modification mechanism or change management process?

Answer 3: The Request for Information (RFI) is issued for market research purposes only. The scope identified in the draft Statement of Objectives represents the Government's best understanding at this time of the requirement of Division C Joint Explanatory Statement for the 2026 Appropriations Act (P.L. 119-74). The Explanatory Act further directs the Secretaries to consult with appropriators prior to initiation of the feasibility study.

The Government intends to clearly define requirements in any resulting solicitation to minimize the need for scope changes during contract performance. Any changes to scope, if required, would be addressed in accordance with applicable contract terms and the Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR), including the use of formal contract modifications issued by the Contracting Officer.

4. Will the contractor have access to interagency data from both the USDA Forest Service and DOI bureaus?

Answer 4: The Request for Information (RFI) is issued for information and planning purposes only. The Government anticipates facilitating access to relevant information and coordinating engagement with appropriate personnel across the USDA Forest Service to support completion of the study, as appropriate and consistent with applicable laws, regulations, and policies.

Respondents are encouraged to describe anticipated data needs, including Government-furnished information, and any considerations related to data access that may affect their analytical approach.

5. What government-furnished data, reports, and personnel access will be provided? Within what timeline can the government commit to responding to contractor requests?

Answer 5: The Request for Information (RFI) is issued for information and planning purposes only. The Government anticipates providing access to relevant Government-furnished information, reports, and personnel from the USDA Forest Service, as appropriate and consistent with applicable laws, regulations, and policies.

The Government cannot commit to specific response timelines at this stage; however, timely support will be provided to the extent practicable to support contract performance.

Respondents are encouraged to identify anticipated data needs, required personnel engagement, and any assumptions regarding Government response timelines that may affect their analytical approach.

6. Will the feasibility study require legal analysis of statutory authorities, appropriations law, or regulatory requirements? If so, will the government require or restrict the use of legal counsel as part of the performing team or will the contractor have access to agency counsel from USDA or DOI to inform legal findings and, if so, under what parameters?

Answer 6: This Request for Information (RFI) is issued for information and planning purposes only. The feasibility study is expected to include, where necessary and appropriate, an analysis of relevant statutory authorities, appropriations structures, and regulatory considerations as they relate to the consolidation of federal wildland fire management functions.

The Government does not intend to prescribe specific team composition at this stage.

Respondents should propose an approach and team structure necessary for addressing legal and policy considerations, including any assumptions regarding expertise or resources required, that are consistent with the objectives of the study.

Contracts/Acquisition

7. Will the government require advance notification or approval for subcontracts?

Answer 7: This Request for Information (RFI) is issued for market research purposes only. Objectives related to subcontracting, including any notification or approval processes, will be addressed in any resulting solicitation and contract.

The Government anticipates that subcontracting will be managed in accordance with applicable Federal Acquisition Regulations (FAR) requirements and standard contract terms.

8. Will the government require formal teaming agreements or subcontracting plans to be submitted with the proposal, or is identification of key teaming partners in the staffing plan sufficient?

Answer 8: This Request for Information (RFI) is issued for market research purposes only. Proposal submission requirements, including any requirements related to teaming arrangements,

subcontracting plans, or identification of subcontractors, will be defined in any resulting solicitation.

Respondents are encouraged to provide input on typical industry practices regarding team structure and proposal documentation.

9. Should the RFI be single or double spaced?

Answer 9: Single Spaced

10. Our organization is active in SAM.gov but is in the process of updating its NAICS codes and renewing its registration. Will you consider RFI materials in advance of this update?

Answer 10: The Request for Information (RFI) is issued for market research purposes only. The Government will consider all responses received, regardless of the respondent's current System for Award Management (SAM.gov) registration status.

Respondents are advised that SAM.gov registration requirements will apply to any resulting solicitation or contract award, as applicable.

11. What is the government's anticipated solicitation release date and contract award date?

Answer 11: This Request for Information (RFI) is issued for market research purposes only. As stated in the RFI, a solicitation may be issued at a later date.

The Government anticipates, but does not guarantee, release of a solicitation in the May timeframe, with contract award timing to be determined based on the acquisition schedule.